

The Art of Shooting the Edit

Editors more often than not appear after all the footage has been shot and are simply regarded as technicians who must stitch together the shots. But if you're reading this it's unlikely you work as an editor in any professional category and are exploring ways of editing your own footage. In that respect you are the definitive artist - writer, director, cinematographer, editor - a real movie storyteller. With that in mind it's important to learn how to incorporate elements of editing when you're shooting a movie or story of any kind.

It's important to remember your limits in the technical realm. You may have a really impressive story that calls for a lot of unique visual shots but nothing beats a steady hand or tripod combined with good performances. The trouble is that without the high end production equipment like Steadicams and camera dollies, you aren't going to get smooth footage of a chase sequence. And this will be your undoing in the editing room because you'll be forced to put shaky, unsteady and distracting footage in your film.

So when you're shooting scenes for your story remember to imagine how you would deal with them in an editing environment. The editing process relies on clean and steady footage for maximum impact. Design your story and shooting process' around these limitations so that your audience isn't left with awesome footage which they can't see because you had to shoot it by hand. A tripod is your friend.

Another aspect of editing to remember when shooting is the visual symmetry of shots. In one of the 20th century's most iconic movies Stanley Kubrick employs this skill masterfully in the form of a "jump cut". This is a choice in editing when you suddenly go from one part of the story to another by cutting together footage from different parts of the story, like moving from one location to another. In 2001 A Space Odyssey, we see a scene in prehistoric times when an apeman like creature discovers tools when using bones, the bone flies into the air and a "jump cut" takes us from the flying bone to a flying space station in the future. This editing choice connects the theme of technology, tools and evolution with one simple "jump cut" showing us how far that apeman has come.

Keep the idea of visual symmetry in the footage when shooting and try your best to keep the editing process active. When in doubt always choose stability over style, emphasise performance over action, and when shooting try and get as many interesting visual perspectives of the same scene so you have options to cut between in the editing room. Independent film making relies on the limitation of money and technology to create interesting story